IOWA BANKERS ASSOCIATION · MARKETING AND COMMUNICATIONS

Bank Note Redesign

Prototypes, Constant Contact build plan and Education Bulletin merge

Oct. 14, 2026 · Working draft

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Links in the mockups are placeholders. “Why it matters” lines are drafts pending review by government relations.

Recommendations at a glance

Bank Note redesign

- **Lead with the week's most important news, not an automatic feature.** Every item gets a headline, a one-sentence lede, a **Why it matters** line and one link.
- **Target length: 900 words or less.** Prototype 1 rebuilds the Oct. 8 issue at 748 words, down from about 1,470. That's a 3-minute read instead of 6.
- **Keep the member sections in fixed spots:** People and Places, Banking in the Community, Member Spotlight and Photo of the Week as the closing "happy card."
- **Keep all five sponsor ad units.** In a shorter issue each ad sits closer to the top.
- **Measure clicks, not opens.** Add UTM tags to every link so Google Analytics shows clicks by section.

Platform: stay in Constant Contact

- Everything in the new format can be built with standard Constant Contact blocks. No custom code.
- The one limit: no jump links inside an email, so "In this issue" is a plain-text scan list.
- **Axios HQ** lists at about $15,000 a year as a starting price, with custom pricing. It wouldn't replace Constant Contact (event promos and the IBMC and IBIS sends stay there), so the real comparison is about $12,000 a year now against roughly $27,000 or more. It's aimed mainly at internal communications.
- Revisit after 8 to 12 redesigned issues if writing consistency, not layout, becomes the bottleneck.

Education Bulletin merge

- The Bulletin becomes a standing, branded section in Bank Note. Recommended name: **Credit Hours**. Alternates: Compound Interest, Capital Gains, The Learning Ledger and Rate Sheet.
- **Every webinar is listed with its own link**, as Education requires. Seminars and schools are highlighted, with a link to the full calendar.
- It replaces Coming up and gets a line in "In this issue" every week. Prototype 2 runs about 950 words, about 210 of them in the education section.

Before launch

1. Have government relations check every "Why it matters" line on regulatory items.
2. Confirm that sponsor contracts allow the new ad positions and a one-line Member Spotlight credit.
3. With Education: pick the section name, define "every webinar" (the mockup uses every webinar until the next issue) and set a weekly handoff (Tuesday noon for a Thursday send).
4. Decide how to handle the 10% of Bulletin contacts who aren't on Bank Note, and send a farewell Bulletin.
5. Build the master template in Constant Contact, pull baseline click data from recent issues and talk with 5 to 10 member bankers.

BANK NOTE REDESIGN · PROTOTYPE 1

The Oct. 8 issue, rebuilt for a three-minute read

Same week's content, new structure: the most important news leads, every item says why it matters and the member sections keep their spots. Every block below is a standard Constant Contact block. No custom code.

~~1,470~~ → 748	~~15~~ → 10	~~6 min~~ → 3 min	5 → 5
words in the body	stories and member items	read time at 250 wpm	sponsor ad units kept

FROM Iowa Bankers Association

SUBJECT **The Fed is redrawing its supervision map**

PREHEADER Plus: A crypto kiosk operator shut down, community banks eye tokenized deposits and 2 Iowa bank deals.

BANK NOTE

WEEKLY NEWS IN BRIEF

IOWA BANKERS ASSOCIATION

Thursday, Oct. 8, 2026 — 3-minute read

IN THIS ISSUE

- The Fed is redrawing its supervision map
- 34 states shut down a crypto kiosk operator
- By the numbers: Tokenized deposits are coming
- Coming up: ABA core survey closes Monday
- Meet the 2026 Leaders in Advocacy grads
- People and Places: 2 Iowa bank deals

TOP STORY

The Fed is redrawing its supervision map



Fed Vice Chair for Supervision Michelle Bowman announced plans to organize bank supervision into five regions drawn along state lines, replacing the 12 Reserve Bank districts.

> **Why it matters:** If the Fed supervises your bank or holding company, your examiners aren't changing. The chain of command above them is. Each region gets one leader responsible for supervision, which the Fed says will simplify decisions and improve coordination with other regulators.

- Examiners stay in their current Reserve Bank offices and keep the banks they supervise now.
- Bowman announced the plan at the Community Banking Research Conference in St. Louis.

Read Bowman's speech



POLICY AND INDUSTRY

34 states shut down a crypto kiosk operator

State regulators, including the Iowa Division of Banking, reached a $2.5 million settlement with Coinme Inc. over Bank Secrecy Act and anti-money laundering violations. Coinme must end its kiosk operations by Jan. 1, 2027.

> **Why it matters:** Crypto kiosks are a common tool in the scams your front line works to stop, and Iowa's regulator was at the table. **Read the settlement**

Iowa's economic outlook stays positive

The Iowa Business Council's third-quarter survey of the state's 22 largest employers rose slightly to 64.91. Anything above 50 is positive.

> **Why it matters:** Capital spending posted the biggest gain, a good sign for commercial loan demand. Workforce challenges remain a top concern. **See the survey**

BY THE NUMBERS

18%

of community banks plan to offer tokenized deposits in the next 12 months, up from 4% that offer them today. Another 16% plan to offer stablecoin solutions, up from 3%.

Source: Conference of State Bank Supervisors, 2026 Annual Survey of Community Banks

Your next step: The IBA is one of 40 state associations in the BankChain Alliance, an industry-owned payments network targeting a 2027 launch. **Learn about BankChain**



COMING UP

Oct. 13 ABA Core Platform Providers Survey closes. Anonymous, about 15 minutes. **Take the survey**

Oct. 27-28 IBA Technology Conference: AI, cyber risk, cybercrime and IT. **Register**

Nov. 18 FDIC webinar on disaster recovery partnerships and CRA consideration (rescheduled). **Register**





FROM THE IBA



Meet the 2026 Leaders in Advocacy grads

Eight bankers wrapped up a year of advocacy training that took them to the Iowa Capitol twice and to Washington to meet with members of Congress, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and federal regulators. Each closed the program with a personal advocacy plan for their bank.

From left: Travis Eagle, Ohnward Bank & Trust; Amy Whitaker, Mediapolis Savings Bank; Josh Craighead, Northwest Bank; Crystal Wright, Community State Bank; Mike Cisney, Lincoln Savings Bank; Nicky Simpson, Bank Midwest; Kelsey Ray, West Bank; and Heather Smith, Denver Savings Bank.

Your next step: Know an emerging leader? Applications for the 2027 class are open. **Apply or nominate**

PEOPLE AND PLACES



DEALS

- **Iowa State Bank**, Algona, and Mid-Iowa Bancshares Co. plan to acquire Swea City Bancorporation Inc., holding company of Estherville-based Bank Plus.
- **Blackhawk Bancorporation**, Milan, Ill., plans to acquire Liberty Bancorporation, holding company of Durant-based Liberty Trust & Savings Bank.

MOVES

- **Heartland Bank**, Somers: CEO Kevin Black will retire at the end of January after 43 years.
- **Citizens First Bank**, Clinton: Kristine Wiersema promoted to Morrison branch manager.
- **Northwest Bank**, Spencer: Wendy Stenberg hired as wealth advisor.
- **Fortress Bank**, Peoria, Ill.: Jarret Mulholland hired as Des Moines market director.

BANKING IN THE COMMUNITY



FreedomBank backs a veterans memorial

FreedomBank gave $2,000 to the Giard Northeast Iowa Vietnam Veterans Memorial Park, a community project honoring Vietnam veterans from across northeast Iowa.

Iowa banks give more than $50.4 million and 300,000 volunteer hours a year. **Share your bank's story**

MEMBER SPOTLIGHT



Backes finds the story behind the numbers

Kenedy Backes, credit portfolio manager at Bankers Trust, calls herself a storyteller: her job is explaining the gray area in the numbers. Best career advice she's received? Be patient and don't rush the season you're in.

Read her story

Member Spotlight is brought to you by IBA associate member **Abrigo**. **Nominate a banker**

PHOTO OF THE WEEK



Matt Johnson of Community Savings Bank met Benny at the IBA Annual Convention, where the Animal Rescue League was the featured nonprofit. Benny went home with the Johnsons. 🐶



What would make Bank Note essential to you? Tell us in one question

Published by the Iowa Bankers Association. Send news to editor@iowabankers.com.

Iowa Bankers Association | 8901 Northpark Drive | Johnston, IA 50131 · Unsubscribe | Update Profile

Build order in Constant Contact

1. Copy last week's campaign and delete everything between the header and footer.
2. Rebuild the skeleton once with the blocks tagged at left, then save it as the Bank Note master. Copy the master every week.
3. Set the subject and preheader first. They name the top story and add a second reason to open.
4. Write the "In this issue" list last, once you know what made the cut.
5. Preview on mobile and send a test to desktop Outlook before every send.

Why no clickable table of contents

Constant Contact's editor doesn't support jump links inside an email, and Gmail and Outlook handle them poorly anyway. "In this issue" is a plain-text scan list. It still does its job: telling a banker in 5 seconds whether to keep scrolling.

What got cut, and where it went

OCT. 8 ITEM	NOW
Leaders in Advocacy feature (330 words)	About 90 words in From the IBA. Full story moves to the website.
Fed supervision restructuring	Promoted to the top story
Digital asset survey + BankChain Alliance	Merged into By the numbers
ABA survey, FDIC webinar	Grouped in Coming up
Habitat CEO build, Bank Security Seminar recap	Cut from the email. Social media and website.
Photo of the week	Moved to the end as the happy card

Before this goes out

- Have the government relations team check each "Why it matters" line. They're drafts written from the original items.
- Confirm sponsor contracts allow a shorter Member Spotlight sponsor line and new ad positions.

Links are placeholders in this mockup.

BANK NOTE REDESIGN · PROTOTYPE 2

Education Bulletin, folded into Bank Note

The redesigned Oct. 8 issue with the Education Bulletin built in as a standing, branded section. Every webinar is listed with its own link, as Education requires. Seminars are highlighted, with a link to the full calendar. One email instead of two, built entirely from standard Constant Contact blocks.

~~2~~ → 1
weekly emails to the same bankers

8 of 8
webinars listed, each with its own link

947
body words, about 210 of them in the education section

2
issues most webinars appear in before their date

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- 34 states shut down a crypto kiosk operator
- By the numbers: Tokenized deposits are coming
- **Credit Hours**: 8 webinars next week, plus Mortgage Lending School
- Meet the 2026 Leaders in Advocacy grads
- People and Places: 2 Iowa bank deals

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> **Why it matters:** Capital spending posted the biggest gain, a good sign for commercial loan demand. Workforce challenges remain a top concern. **See the survey**

Mark your calendar

- **Oct. 13:** ABA's Core Platform Providers Survey closes. Anonymous, about 15 minutes. **Take the survey**
- **Nov. 18:** FDIC webinar on disaster recovery partnerships and CRA consideration (rescheduled). **Register**

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Credit Hours

TRAINING THAT COUNTS · IBA EDUCATION

FEATURED

2026 IBA Technology Conference

Oct. 27-28 · Des Moines

Two days on artificial intelligence, cyber risk management, cybercrime and IT, with time to meet vendors and grow your network.

Register for the conference

WEBINARS NEXT WEEK

All 8, Oct. 12-15

Mon., Oct. 12	Best-Ever Compliance Checklists for Commercial Loans
Tue., Oct. 13	FCRA Compliance
	Completing a SAR: ID Theft, Elder Fraud, Cash and Check Transactions
	Accurately Completing the SAR: A Workshop Going Beyond the Basics
Wed., Oct. 14	Fraudulent Cashier's Checks: Best Practices for Avoiding Losses
	2026 Deposit Operations Webinar ALL DAY
Thu., Oct. 15	2026 BSA Officer and Staff Webinar ALL DAY
	Appraisal Bias, AVMs and Reconsiderations of Value: How Should We Handle This?

SEMINARS AND SCHOOLS

In person

LAST CALL **Deposit Account Administration Seminar**
Oct. 14, Cedar Rapids · Oct. 15, West Des Moines

Mortgage Lending School
Oct. 20-21, Johnston

Iowa Lending Law Seminar
Oct. 22, Johnston

Advanced IRA Seminar
Oct. 27, Storm Lake · Oct. 28, Johnston · Oct. 29, Cedar Rapids

Training tool of the week: New branch manager? IBA's on-demand webinars cover supervisory skills and running a high-performing branch. **See branch manager training**

See the full education calendar

Questions about training? **Contact IBA Education**



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FROM THE IBA



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Published by the Iowa Bankers Association. Send news to editor@iowabankers.com.

Iowa Bankers Association | 8901 Northpark Drive | Johnston, IA 50131 · Unsubscribe | Update Profile

Section name ideas

Credit Hours (recommended)

Two meanings bankers get instantly: credit is their business, and credit hours are what training earns. Short enough for a label and a subject line (“Credit Hours: 8 webinars next week”).

Compound Interest

Learning builds on itself the way interest does. Warm, a little clever.

Capital Gains

Carries the Bulletin’s old “Opportunities for growth” tagline. Leans toward professional development.

The Learning Ledger

Every training on the books. Literal, easy to explain to Education.

Rate Sheet

Plays on the sheet every banker knows. Fits the scannable list format best.

Use the buttons above the email to see each name in place.

Education’s requirements, met

- **Every webinar listed and linked.** All 8 from the Bulletin appear, each with its own registration link.
- **Seminars can be highlighted.** Four in-person events are shown, with “Last call” on the one happening this week, plus a link to the full calendar.
- **Training tool of the week** carries over from the Bulletin as one line.

What Education gets in the upgrade

- **Its own brand inside Bank Note.** A standing banner in the same spot every week, so bankers learn where training lives.
- **A line in “In this issue.”** Training gets a teaser above the fold every week.
- **Two shots at every webinar.** List each webinar from the issue before its date through the date itself. With a weekly send, most webinars appear twice.
- **Webinar-level click data.** Tag each link with `utm_content=webinar-[short-name]` and Education can see clicks and registrations per webinar.
- **Mobile-friendly listings.** One column grouped by day replaces the Bulletin’s two columns, which stack in a confusing order on phones.

The length trade-off

The issue grows from about 750 to about 950 words. About 210 of those are in the education section, mostly listings that bankers scan rather than read. To stay near the 900-word target, Coming up was folded in: Education events moved here, and outside deadlines moved to “Mark your calendar” under Policy and industry.

Confirm with Education

- Does “every webinar” mean every webinar in the next two weeks, or everything on the calendar? This mockup lists every webinar until the next issue goes out.
- Who sends the weekly list, and by what day? Suggest Tuesday noon for a Thursday send.
- Pick the name together. Letting Education choose it helps them own the section.

Links are placeholders in this mockup.

Building the new Bank Note in Constant Contact

How to build the redesigned issue with Constant Contact's standard drag-and-drop blocks. No custom code. The working mockup is `prototype/bank-note-prototype.html`. Open it in a browser and turn on **Show Constant Contact blocks** to see which block builds each section.

One-time setup: build a master template

1. Copy a recent Bank Note campaign so the header, colors and footer carry over.
2. Delete everything between the header image and the footer.
3. Build the skeleton below with placeholder text in every block, such as "HEADLINE: what happened or what to do."
4. Name it **Bank Note MASTER (do not send)** and copy it each week instead of last week's issue. Copying last week's issue is how old content and old structure creep back in.
5. Set the global styles once (fonts, link color, button color) so every weekly copy inherits them. Stick with Arial or another web-safe font so desktop Outlook renders it as designed.

The skeleton, block by block

#	Section	Constant Contact block	Notes
0	Subject and preheader	Email settings	Subject names the top story. The preheader adds a second reason to open and doesn't repeat the subject.
1	Header	Image block	Current Bank Note banner, unchanged
2	Date and read time	Text block	"Thursday, Oct. 8, 2026 · 3-minute read"
3	In this issue	Text block with a light section fill	4 to 6 one-line teasers, plain text (see below)
4	Section label	Text block with a blue fill	Reuse this one label block for every section: copy it and change the words.
5	Top story	Image + Text block, Text block, Button block	Headline, one-sentence lede, **Why it matters:**, 1 or 2 bullets, one button
6	Sponsor ad 1	Image block (linked)	Highest-value ad position, right below the top story
7	Policy and industry	Text blocks separated by Divider blocks	2 or 3 items: bold headline, 1 to 2 sentences, **Why it matters:** plus a link
8	By the numbers	2-column layout: Text block and Text block	One big stat on the left, context and **Your next step:** on the right
9	Sponsor ad 2	Image block	
10	Coming up	Text block	Bold date, one line, one link. Events, education and deadlines live here and nowhere else.
11	Sponsor ads 3 and 4	2-column layout: Image block and Image block	Square ads side by side
12	From the IBA	Image block and Text block	At most one IBA story. Full features live on the website.

#	Section	Constant Contact block	Notes
13	People and Places	Image block (headshot strip) and Text block	Split into **Deals** and **Moves**, one line each
14	Banking in the Community	Image + Text block (image left)	Photo, 2 sentences, submit link
15	Member Spotlight	Image + Text block, Text block (sponsor line)	About 50 words plus “Read her story”
16	Photo of the week	Image block and Text block	The closing “happy card”
17	Sponsor ad 5	Image block	
18	Footer	Text block and the required Footer block	Feedback question, editor email, legal footer

Sections 12 to 16 are the standing member sections. They stay in the same order every week so readers learn where to find them.

Things Constant Contact won’t do, and the workaround

- **No jump links.** Constant Contact’s editor doesn’t support anchor links inside an email, and its staff say Gmail and Outlook handle them poorly. “In this issue” is a plain-text scan list. That still meets the goal: telling a banker in a few seconds whether to keep reading.
- **No per-reader content.** Everyone gets the same issue. Order the issue for the typical banker and let “In this issue” do the personalizing.
- **Image + Text blocks stack on phones.** That’s fine. Keep images small (150 to 200 pixels wide) so a phone reader isn’t scrolling past a giant headshot.

Tag links so clicks show by section

Constant Contact’s click report lists clicks by URL. For a section-level view in Google Analytics, add the same UTM tags to each link, changing only `utm_content`:

```
?utm_source=banknote&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=bn-2026-10-08&utm_content=top-story
```

Use `top-story`, `policy-1`, `policy-2`, `numbers`, `coming-up`, `from-iba`, `people-places`, `community`, `spotlight`, `photo`. After 8 to 12 issues you’ll know which sections earn clicks. That data answers the open questions in `proposed-structure.md` better than opinions will.

Weekly production checklist

1. Copy the master. Pick the top story first: “Is this the most important thing for an Iowa banker this week?”
2. Fill sections top to bottom. If a section has nothing good this week, delete it. Don’t fill it for the sake of filling it.
3. Write “In this issue,” the subject and the preheader last.
4. Check the length. Target 900 words or less, not counting the footer. (The prototype is 748.)

5. Have policy staff check every “Why it matters” line on regulatory items.
6. Send tests to a phone and to desktop Outlook, with images on and off.
7. Score the issue against `redesign-checklist.md`.

Same template for IBMC and IBIS

Each company keeps its own Constant Contact account, contacts and billing, and nothing here changes that. Once the Bank Note master works, rebuild the same skeleton in the IBMC and IBIS accounts with their own header, colors and section names. The writing format (headline, lede, Why it matters, link) carries over unchanged.

Sponsor considerations

The prototype keeps all five ad units from the Oct. 8 issue. A shorter issue helps sponsors: each ad sits closer to the top, so more readers scroll past it. Before launch:

- Confirm sponsor contracts allow the new ad positions.
- Confirm the Member Spotlight sponsor accepts a one-line credit (“brought to you by IBA associate member Abrigo”) in place of the full paragraph, or link the full description.
- Consider whether five ads in a 750-word issue is too heavy. Four may read better, with the fifth position rotating.

Folding the Education Bulletin into Bank Note

The Education Bulletin is being sunset. About 90% of its contacts already get Bank Note, so its content moves into Bank Note as a standing section. That serves a separate incentive goal: fewer emails to members. The mockup is `prototype/bank-note-education-merge.html`.

Education's requirements

Requirement	How the section meets it
Every webinar listed, each with a clickable link	Every webinar between this issue and the next is listed by day, and each title is its own registration link. No "see more webinars" shortcut.
Other events can be highlighted, with a link to the rest	"Seminars and schools" shows 3 or 4 in-person events, plus a button to the full education calendar
(Bulletin carryover) Training tool of the week	Kept as one line with a link

Confirm with Education: does "every webinar" mean every webinar before the next issue, or everything on the calendar? The mockup uses a rolling window, which matches what the Bulletin did.

Section name

Recommended: **Credit Hours**. Credit is the banker's business, and credit hours are what training earns. It works as a label, an "In this issue" line and a subject-line hook: "Credit Hours: 8 webinars next week."

Alternatives: **Compound Interest** (learning builds on itself), **Capital Gains** (keeps the Bulletin's "Opportunities for growth" spirit), **The Learning Ledger** (every training on the books) and **Rate Sheet** (training at a glance, in a format every banker knows).

Let Education make the final pick. Choosing the name helps them own the section. Banner images for all five are in `prototype/images/banners/` at 1200 pixels wide, ready to upload to Constant Contact at 600.

Where it sits in the issue

Credit Hours replaces the old Coming up section, in the same position: after By the numbers and sponsor ad 2, before From the IBA. Outside deadlines (ABA surveys, regulator webinars) move to a short "Mark your calendar" item at the end of Policy and industry.

Credit Hours also gets a line in "In this issue" every week, such as "Credit Hours: 8 webinars next week, plus Mortgage Lending School." That puts training above the fold even though the section sits mid-issue.

Section structure (Constant Contact blocks)

1. **Banner.** Image block with the name banner. Same image every week.
2. **Featured.** Text block with a white card look and a Button block. One event that Education wants pushed hardest that week, with dates, location, one sentence and a register button.

3. **Webinars.** One Text block. Bold day (“Tue., Oct. 13”), then each webinar title as a link. Tag all-day sessions “All day.” Use one column, not the Bulletin’s two: Constant Contact stacks columns on phones, which scrambles the date order.
4. **Seminars and schools.** One Text block with 3 or 4 events. Linked name, then dates and cities on the next line. Add “Last call” to anything happening before the next issue.
5. **Training tool of the week.** One Text block, one sentence and a link.
6. **Calendar link.** Button block (“See the full education calendar”) plus a one-line “Contact IBA Education” Text block.

Give the whole section a light blue fill so it reads as its own space within Bank Note.

Weekly workflow with Education

When	Who	What
Tuesday by noon	Education	Send the webinar list for the window (each title, date and link), the featured event and the tool of the week
Wednesday	Marketing	Build the section, write the “In this issue” line and the featured blurb
Wednesday	Education	Quick proof of the section: titles, dates and links
Thursday	Marketing	Bank Note sends

A shared spreadsheet with columns for title, date, link, type and featured (yes or no) is easier than email. Education keeps it current, and marketing copies from it.

Tracking (Education will want proof)

Tag every education link with UTM parameters so Google Analytics shows clicks per webinar:

```
?utm_source=banknote&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=bn-2026-10-08&utm_content=edu-webinar-fcra
```

Use `edu-featured`, `edu-webinar-[short-name]`, `edu-seminar-[short-name]`, `edu-tool` and `edu-calendar`. Before the switch, pull 8 to 12 weeks of Education Bulletin clicks and webinar registrations from the Bulletin as the baseline. Then report the same numbers to Education monthly after the merge. If webinar registrations hold or rise, the merge has earned its keep.

Sunsetting the Bulletin

1. **Handle the other 10%.** Export Bulletin contacts who aren’t on the Bank Note list. Decide with Education whether to add them to Bank Note, which is the same sender and the same kind of content, or invite them to subscribe. Adding them, plus an easy opt-out, keeps the most webinar reach.
2. **Send a final Bulletin**, two weeks before the switch: “Education Bulletin is moving into Bank Note. Find every webinar in Credit Hours each Thursday.” Show a screenshot of the new section.
3. **First merged issue.** Give Credit Hours the top “In this issue” line and a short note introducing the section.

4. **Retire the list** after the final send. Keep the list, but stop scheduled sends.

Length

Adding the section takes the Oct. 8 prototype from about 750 words to about 950. About 210 of those are education listings, which bankers scan rather than read. To stay near the target, write tightly elsewhere. In a heavy news week, cut a policy item before cutting webinars.

Prototype 1 scorecard

The Oct. 8, 2026, issue rebuilt in the new format (`prototype/bank-note-prototype.html`), scored against `redesign-checklist.md`.

	Oct. 8 as sent	Prototype 1
Body words (no ads or legal footer)	About 1,470	748
Read time at 250 words a minute	About 6 minutes	About 3 minutes
Stories and member items	15	10
Sponsor ad units	5	5
Lead item	Leaders in Advocacy feature	Fed supervision restructuring

Checklist results

Length and selection: Pass. 748 words with 5 news items (top story, 2 policy items, By the numbers, From the IBA) plus Coming up and the member sections. The Habitat build and the Bank Security Seminar recap were cut, not shortened.

First screen: Pass, pending a real-inbox test. The subject names the top story, the preheader adds three more hooks and “In this issue” sits right under the header.

Every item: Mostly pass. Every news item has a headline that stands on its own, a one-sentence lede, a “Why it matters” line and one descriptive link. The “Why it matters” lines are drafts and need a check by the government relations team.

Scannability and design: Pass in the mockup. Three recurring labels: **Why it matters**, **Your next step** and **By the numbers**. One emoji, on the happy card only. Still to test: desktop Outlook and images-off rendering in a real Constant Contact build.

Flow and member content: Pass. The order runs from federal policy to IBA news, then member sections, then the Photo of the week as the happy card. Events are grouped in Coming up.

Audience and accuracy: Needs review. All facts come from the Oct. 8 issue as sent, and the links are placeholders.

Judgment calls to discuss

1. **Top story.** I picked the Fed restructuring over the crypto kiosk settlement because it affects how Fed-supervised Iowa banks are examined. The kiosk story is the stronger “talker.” Either is defensible.
2. **Photo of the week as the happy card.** The puppy photo beats Member Spotlight as an ending. Spotlight stays just above it.
3. **Leaders in Advocacy** dropped from a 330-word lead feature to about 90 words in From the IBA. The full story belongs on the website, with a link if one exists.
4. **People and Places** moved up, ahead of the community sections, because bank deals are high-interest news and it now gets an “In this issue” line.

Platform options: stay in Constant Contact or move?

As of Oct. 12, 2026. Pricing below comes from third-party software listings, not quotes. Confirm everything with the vendor.

Recommendation

Stay in Constant Contact for the redesign. The problem with Bank Note is length and story selection, not the software. Everything in the new format (scan list, Why it matters, labels, member sections) can be built with Constant Contact's standard blocks; see `constant-contact-build-guide.md`. Run the new format for 8 to 12 issues, measure clicks, then decide whether a tool would fix a remaining problem.

Axios HQ

What it is: Software built around Smart Brevity. It's an editor that coaches writers (AI shortening, structure prompts, style checks), plus distribution and reader analytics. It's marketed mainly for internal and stakeholder communications. Its listed integrations sync audiences from company directories such as Outlook, Gmail, Workday and Okta. Distribution includes email, Slack, Microsoft Teams and SharePoint.

Price: Software listings put the starting price at about **$15,000 a year**. Pricing is custom, based on organization size and needs. There's no free version or free trial. G2 lists one edition with unlimited team members and contacts. No public source says whether $15,000 covers one organization or several, so that has to come from Axios HQ sales.

The math that matters: Axios HQ would sit beside Constant Contact, not replace it. Event promos, registration emails and the IBMC and IBIS sends would all stay in Constant Contact. So the comparison isn't $15,000 against $12,000. It's 12,000*againstroughly* * *27,000 or more** a year for all three companies.

What reviewers say: Most praise the writing coach and analytics. The most common complaints are price and a steep learning curve. Review counts are small, about a dozen on some sites.

Questions for Axios HQ if you take a demo

1. Does one contract cover three separate organizations, each with its own audience, branding and reporting?
2. Is it built for an external member list of several thousand, including unsubscribes and CAN-SPAM compliance, or mainly for employee lists?
3. Can it import our Constant Contact lists and keep them in sync, or would we manage contacts in two places?
4. What does the analytics view show that Constant Contact plus UTM-tagged links doesn't?
5. Will you run a pilot on one newsletter (Bank Note only) at a lower price?

Ways to get most of the Axios benefit for less

- **Learn the method, not the software.** The Smart Brevity book, plus the free Smart Brevity 101 guide from Axios HQ, cover the writing rules. The redesign checklist already turns them into a weekly standard.

- **Use AI as the writing coach.** Paste a draft item into Claude and ask for a Smart Brevity version against `redesign-checklist.md`, then verify against the source. That covers most of what the Axios HQ editor does, at no added cost.
- **Get section-level analytics from UTM tags.** Tagged links in Google Analytics show which sections earn clicks, which is Axios HQ's main reporting selling point.

When to revisit

Reconsider a dedicated tool if, after 8 to 12 redesigned issues:

- Click-to-open hasn't moved and the issue is still running long, meaning the team needs a stronger writing guardrail than a checklist, or
- Several IBA staff are writing for Bank Note and holding a consistent voice has become the bottleneck.

Sources

- Axios HQ pricing (Capterra)
- Axios HQ pricing (G2)
- Axios HQ reviews and pricing (Software Advice)
- Axios HQ (GetApp)
- Axios HQ (Wikipedia)
- Constant Contact community: Table of contents block
- Constant Contact community: Hyperlinks to text within email

APPENDIX

Research findings

As of Oct. 12, 2026. Sources are linked inline and collected in `sources.md`.

Bottom line

Bank Note should be built for a banker who gives it under a minute and skims most of it. Every structural choice should help that reader find the two or three things that matter to them, then choose whether to go deeper.

- **Time is the constraint.** People look at a typical email for about 9 seconds, and newsletter readers average under a minute per issue. The first screen does most of the work.
- **Skimming is the default, not the failure.** Most newsletters get skimmed rather than read. Structure (labels, bold lead-ins, short blocks) is what makes skimming productive.
- **Selection beats compression.** Axios-style issues stay short by picking fewer, better items, not by squeezing long articles into less space.
- **Measure clicks, not opens.** Apple's privacy features inflate open rates, so clicks per story and click-to-open rate are the honest readouts.

Practical target: roughly 900 words or a three-minute read, an "In this issue" scan list at the top, one lead item with a "Why it matters" line and the popular member sections kept as recurring, recognizable blocks.

Findings

Finding	The number	Source	What it means for Bank Note
Time spent on a typical email	About 9 seconds on average, down from 13.4 seconds in 2018	Litmus via MarketingProfs	Subject line, preheader and first screen decide whether anything else gets seen.
How that time splits	30% of emails get under 2 seconds, 41% get 2 to 8 seconds, 29% get more than 8	Same as above	Design for the 2-to-8-second skimmer: labels and bold lead-ins, not paragraphs.
Time spent on a newsletter	51 seconds on average after opening	Nielsen Norman Group via Slideshare	At about 250 words a minute, that's roughly 200 words of real reading.
Read vs. skimmed	Only 19% of newsletters read thoroughly; 69% skimmed	Smart Insights on NN/g	Skimming is the main use case.
Partial skimming	35% of the time, readers skimmed only a small part of the newsletter	Nielsen Norman Group via Slideshare	Most important item first; below the first scroll may never be seen.
What readers ask for	"Keep it brief" was the most common advice; frequency was the top complaint	The Communication Initiative on NN/g	Length is a retention risk, not just a style preference.
Axios article attention	Readers spend about 26 seconds on an article	Journalism.co.uk	Each story needs its point in the first two lines.

Finding	The number	Source	What it means for Bank Note
Axios newsletter performance	46% average open rate; 63% of subscribers click links; 53% forward content	Same as above	Short formats still drive clicks and sharing; links carry the depth.
Smart Brevity length	About 50% shorter than conventional versions	Axios HQ Smart Brevity 101	Realistic goal: cut current Bank Note length roughly in half.
Axios Local newsletter	About 900 words, 5 to 8 stories, three-minute read	Axios speaker (`axios-session-notes.md`)	Concrete length and story-count target.
Association benchmark	Average open rate of 36% for associations and nonprofits	Higher Logic webinar transcript	The right peer group for comparison.
Peer-driven content	Community digest emails drew 44% to 56% opens	Higher Logic	Member-focused sections are likely engagement assets. Keep them prominent.
Banking and financial services	27.42% open rate; 13.43% click-to-open rate	MoEngage	Secondary reference point for click-to-open goals.
Open rates are inflated	One publisher saw unique opens rise from 15.2% to 19.1% after Apple Mail Privacy Protection, while clicks did not rise	Omeda	Judge the redesign on clicks and click-to-open.

Why Smart Brevity works

Smart Brevity has four parts: a tease (headline), a lede (the one new thing), context (“Why it matters”) and choice (a link to go deeper). Axios’ design team built the product around what readers actually do, which is skim (Society for News Design; getAbstract).

Gaps

- None of these sources studies Iowa bankers specifically. Fill the gap with Bank Note’s own data (device mix, click map by section, open times) and conversations with member bankers.
- Bankers likely read at work in desktop Outlook during business hours. Confirm in the email platform’s reports before designing around it.
- The Nielsen Norman newsletter studies are older; newer Litmus data points the same direction.

APPENDIX

Redesign checklist

Run every draft outline, and later every weekly issue, against these criteria. If an item can't be checked, that's the next thing to fix.

Length and selection

- ☐Issue is about 900 words or less (a three-minute read)
- ☐5 to 8 items total, not counting standing member sections
- ☐Each item was selected, not compressed: we picked the 2 or 3 points bankers need, not a shortened version of everything
- ☐Nothing is in the issue just because it was in last week's issue
- ☐Long content (full regulatory summaries, feature stories) lives on the website, with Bank Note linking out

The first screen (the 9-second test)

- ☐Subject line names the single most useful item, not just "Bank Note, Oct. 14"
- ☐Preheader text adds a second reason to open rather than repeating the subject
- ☐An "In this issue" list of 4 to 6 one-line items sits above the fold
- ☐The lead item is the most important news of the week, not automatically a feature
- ☐A reader who stops after the first screen still knows the week's top takeaway

Every item

- ☐Headline says what happened or what to do (teaches something on its own)
- ☐First sentence is the news; second answers "Why it matters" for an Iowa banker
- ☐Body is 1 to 3 short paragraphs or bullets, one idea each
- ☐Strong words sit at the start or end of sentences; no wordy adverbs or filler
- ☐One clear link to go deeper, with descriptive link text (not "click here")
- ☐Passes the "talker" test: would one banker bring this up with another?

Scannability and design

- ☐Recurring bold labels used consistently (e.g., Why it matters, By the numbers, Coming up, Your next step)
- ☐Clear visual separation between sections so skimmers can jump
- ☐Visuals or icons break up text where they help, used sparingly and never next to serious news

- ☐Reads cleanly on a phone and in desktop Outlook (test both before every send)
- ☐Layout doesn’t depend on images loading to make sense

Flow and member content

- ☐Order runs serious to lighter: top news, then regulatory and education, then member sections
- ☐People and Places, Banking in the Community and Member Spotlight appear in the same spot every week
- ☐Issue ends on a positive “happy card” (Member Spotlight or Banking in the Community is a natural fit)
- ☐Events and education promos are grouped, not scattered through the issue

Audience and accuracy

- ☐Content passes “Is this important to an Iowa banker, and why?”
- ☐Any AI-assisted summaries were checked against the original source
- ☐AP style applied throughout

APPENDIX

Proposed Bank Note structure

A starting skeleton to prototype against, running top to bottom from most serious to most positive. Word counts are targets that add up to roughly 900.

1. **Subject line and preheader** — the top item named plainly, plus a second hook in the preheader.
2. **In this issue (about 60 words)** — 4 to 6 one-line teasers that let a banker pick what to read in a few seconds.
3. **The big one (about 150 words)** — the week's most important news, written Axios-style: what happened, **Why it matters**, one or two supporting bullets, link to go deeper. Replaces the automatic feature article; a feature can still earn this slot when it's the week's biggest story.
4. **Quick hits (about 200 words)** — 3 or 4 short regulatory, advocacy or industry items, each a bold lead-in plus two sentences and a link.
5. **By the numbers (about 50 words)** — one stat bankers would repeat, with one line of context. A recurring, recognizable feature.
6. **Coming up (about 100 words)** — events, education and deadlines grouped in one compact list with dates and register links.
7. **People and Places (about 150 words)** — promotions, new roles and M&As as a scannable list, one line per item.
8. **Banking in the Community or Member Spotlight (about 150 words)** — the closing "happy card," with one photo.
9. **Footer** — feedback link ("What would make Bank Note essential to you?"), preferences and contact.

Item format (every story)

- **Headline:** what happened or what to do
- **Lede (1 sentence):** the news
- **Why it matters (1 to 2 sentences):** the impact on an Iowa banker
- **Optional:** 1 or 2 bullets of supporting detail
- **Link:** descriptive text to go deeper

Open questions

- ☐Does Member Spotlight run every week or rotate with Banking in the Community?
- ☐Should IBMC and IBIS items have a dedicated slot or compete for Quick hits?
- ☐Which recurring labels to commit to (pick 3 or 4 and keep them stable)
- ☐Where the full feature article lives online when it moves out of the email

APPENDIX

Measurement plan

Set a baseline from the last 8 to 12 current-format issues before launch, then compare the redesign over its first 8 to 12 issues. Clicks are the headline measure because open rates are inflated by Apple Mail Privacy Protection.

Metric	Why it matters	Target direction
Click-to-open rate	Best single read on whether opened issues are useful; banking and financial services average about 13%	Up from baseline
Unique click rate (clicks ÷ delivered)	Unaffected by inflated opens	Up from baseline
Clicks by section and position	Shows whether readers reach past the first screen and which recurring sections earn attention	More clicks spread below the lead item
Registrations or actions from Bank Note links	The behavioral outcome that matters most for events and education	Up from baseline
Unsubscribe rate	Early warning if the new format misses	Flat or down
Open rate	Useful only as an aggregate trend, not proof of reading	Hold steady or rise
Reader feedback	Fills the gap the research can’t: what Iowa bankers want	5 to 10 banker conversations before launch, a one-question poll after

Test plan

- ☐Pull baseline click map by section from recent issues
- ☐Talk with 5 to 10 member bankers: “What would make Bank Note essential to you?”
- ☐Build one prototype issue from a real week’s content and score it against the checklist
- ☐Send a prototype to a small internal or friendly-banker group for feedback
- ☐Launch, then review metrics after 4 and 8 issues

Data to bring into this repo

Drop exports in `data/` (create it as needed): per-issue sends, unique opens, unique clicks, clicks by link, unsubscribes, device or client mix and send/open times.

APPENDIX

Sources

Research gathered Oct. 12, 2026.

- How much time do people typically spend looking at an email (Litmus data, MarketingProfs)
- Enewsletter usability: 5 subscriber behaviours to consider (Smart Insights, on Nielsen Norman Group)
- How digital news is consumed (Slideshare, quoting Nielsen Norman Group)
- Targeted email newsletters show continued strength (The Communication Initiative, on Nielsen Norman Group)
- How Axios is reinventing text journalism with Smart Brevity (Journalism.co.uk)
- Smart Brevity 101 (Axios HQ)
- Alexis Lloyd on designing Axios (Society for News Design)
- Smart Brevity book summary (getAbstract)
- 2025 Association Community Benchmark Report (Higher Logic)
- 2025 Association Community Benchmark webinar transcript (Higher Logic)
- Email marketing statistics by industry (MoEngage)
- The impact of Apple's Mail Privacy Protection (Omeda)
- Axios Salt Lake City speaker session notes (`axios-session-notes.md`)
- Claude Doc: Bank Note Redesign: Research-Backed Criteria